

THE EFFECT OF SINGLE PARENTING ON THE ACADEMIC PERFORMANCE OF STUDENTS IN OYO TOWN, OYO STATE, NIGERIA

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ABSTRACT

This study examined the effect of single parenting on the academic performance of secondary school students in Oyo Town, Oyo State, Nigeria. The research was motivated by the increasing prevalence of single-parent households and the growing concern about students' academic outcomes. The study specifically sought to determine the academic performance levels of students from single-parent homes, compare them with those from two-parent homes, identify challenges faced by students from single-parent families, and suggest strategies to enhance their academic success.

A descriptive survey research design was adopted. The population of the study comprised secondary school students in Oyo Town. A sample of 200 students was selected using stratified random sampling techniques. Data were collected through a structured questionnaire and analyzed using descriptive statistics (frequencies and percentages) and inferential statistics (t-test).

Findings revealed that while many students from single-parent homes demonstrate commitment and interest in their studies, there exists a noticeable difference in academic performance between students from single-parent and two-parent families. Financial constraints, limited parental supervision, and emotional stress were identified as major challenges affecting students from single-parent homes. However, the study also found that strong parental support, effective school counseling, and community assistance can significantly mitigate these challenges.

The study concluded that single parenting does not automatically result in poor academic performance; rather, associated socio-economic and emotional factors play a critical role. It was recommended that schools, government agencies, and community organizations implement targeted support programs to enhance academic outcomes for students from single-parent households.

Keywords: Single Parenting, Academic Performance, Secondary School Students, Family Structure, Parental Involvement, Oyo Town.

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background to the Study

Education is widely recognized as a cornerstone for individual and national development. It empowers individuals with the knowledge, skills, and values necessary to contribute meaningfully to society (UNESCO, 2015). For adolescents, secondary education represents a critical phase of intellectual, social, and emotional development, laying the foundation for higher learning and future career prospects. Academic performance, typically measured by grades, examination results, and overall educational attainment, is therefore a key indicator of a student's success and the effectiveness of the educational system (Adeyemi & Adeyinka, 2017).

Globally, various factors have been identified as influencing students' academic outcomes, ranging from school-related variables such as teacher quality, instructional methods, and resource availability to student-related factors like motivation, intelligence, and study habits. However, a significant body of research points to the profound impact of the home environment and family structure on a child's academic trajectory (Bronfenbrenner, 1979; Epstein, 2001). The family, as the primary socialization agent, provides the initial learning environment and shapes a child's values, attitudes, and readiness for formal schooling.

Historically, the traditional nuclear family, comprising two biological parents, has been considered the normative structure for child upbringing. However, contemporary society has witnessed a significant global shift in family structures, with an increasing prevalence of single-parent households (UNICEF, 2017). This demographic change is often attributed to various socio-economic factors, including divorce, separation, death of a spouse, out-of-wedlock births, and economic migration. Consequently, a growing number of children are being raised by only one parent, typically the mother, but increasingly the father.

The implications of growing up in a single-parent household on various aspects of a child's development, including their academic performance, have become a subject of considerable academic and public discourse. Proponents of traditional family structures often raise concerns about the potential challenges faced by single-parent families, such as financial strain, limited parental supervision, emotional stress, and reduced access to social capital (Amato, 2005). These challenges are hypothesized to translate into lower academic achievement for children from such backgrounds compared to their peers from two-parent homes. For instance, single parents may face the dual burden of sole financial provision and childcare, which can limit the time and resources available to assist with homework, attend school functions, or provide a conducive learning environment at home.

Conversely, some studies suggest that the quality of parenting, rather than the family structure itself, is the most critical determinant of child outcomes (McLanahan & Sandefur, 1994). They argue that a single parent who is highly supportive, provides consistent discipline, and actively engages in their child's education can mitigate many of the potential negative effects associated with their family structure. Furthermore, some children from single-parent homes may exhibit resilience and develop

stronger coping mechanisms due to early exposure to responsibility and independence.

In Nigeria, the phenomenon of single-parenting is also on the rise, influenced by factors such as high rates of marital dissolution, increasing incidence of migration, and the impact of socio-cultural norms (NPC & ICF International, 2019). This shift in family dynamics is likely to have significant implications for the educational landscape, particularly in urban and semi-urban centers where social changes are more pronounced. Oyo Town, a prominent historical and administrative center in Oyo State, Nigeria, is not immune to these societal changes. Its growing population and evolving socio-economic dynamics suggest a diverse range of family structures among its residents, including a notable presence of single-parent households. Academic performance of secondary school students in Oyo State, generally, has been a concern, with reports indicating low performance in core subjects like English Language and Mathematics in public examinations (Ajayi, 2011; Olagunju, 2012; Raji & Oyekanmi, 2024).

Despite the global and national interest in this subject, there remains a need for localized studies to understand the specific nuances and effects of single-parenting on academic performance within particular socio-cultural contexts. Previous research on this topic in Nigeria has often been generalized or conducted in different regions, potentially overlooking the unique socio-cultural, economic, and educational realities of specific communities like Oyo Town. Understanding the specific challenges and possible strengths associated with single-parenting in this context is crucial for developing targeted interventions and support systems for students and families.

Therefore, this study aims to investigate the effect of single parenting on the academic performance of secondary school students in Oyo Town, Oyo State, Nigeria. By focusing on this specific geographical location, the research intends to provide empirical evidence that can contribute to a more nuanced understanding of the issue, inform educational policies, and guide interventions designed to enhance the academic outcomes of students from diverse family backgrounds in the region.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

The traditional family structure, characterized by the presence of both biological parents, has historically been viewed as the ideal environment for fostering optimal child development and academic success. However, global demographic shifts, including rising divorce rates, increasing out-of-wedlock births, and instances of spousal death or separation, have led to a significant increase in single-parent households (UN Women, 2020; UNICEF, 2017). This trend is particularly evident in Nigeria, where socio-cultural factors and economic pressures have contributed to a growing number of children being raised by a lone parent (Kainos Edge Data Service, 2020; Punchng.com, 2024).

While general research often highlights potential challenges faced by children from single-parent homes, such as financial constraints, limited parental time and supervision, and increased emotional stress (Amato, 2005; Obong & Etim, 2018), there remains a contentious debate regarding the direct and consistent impact of this family structure on academic performance. Some studies suggest a negative correlation, indicating that students from single-parent families may experience lower academic achievement compared to their peers from two-parent households (Ali & Soomar, 2019; Rubamande et al., 2021). These studies often attribute this to a reduction in available resources,

parental involvement, and a less stable home environment.

Conversely, a substantial body of literature argues that family structure alone may not be the primary determinant of academic success. Instead, the quality of parenting, the socio-economic status of the household, parental involvement, and the provision of a supportive home learning environment are posited as more critical factors, regardless of whether one or two parents are present (McLanahan & Sandefur, 1994; Anyakoha, 2016; Jaiyeola & Akinjide, 2016). This perspective suggests that a highly involved and supportive single parent can effectively mitigate potential disadvantages. Furthermore, some Nigerian studies have found mixed or non-significant effects of single parenting on academic outcomes, sometimes mediated by other variables like student motivation or school support systems (Akinwande et al., 2025).

The lack of consistent findings across various contexts underscores the complexity of this issue. Existing research, particularly within the Nigerian context, often offers generalized insights or focuses on urban centers without specific attention to distinct sub-regional characteristics. Oyo Town, a significant hub in Oyo State, Nigeria, is experiencing its own unique socio-economic transformations that contribute to varying family dynamics. While there are anecdotal observations and concerns among educators and parents in Oyo Town regarding students' academic performance, the specific influence of single parenting within this localized context remains largely unexplored. Are students from single-parent homes in Oyo Town truly performing below their peers from two-parent homes, or are other underlying factors more influential? Are the challenges faced by single-parent families in Oyo Town unique, or do they mirror national trends? Without empirical investigation tailored to this specific environment, it is difficult to develop targeted educational strategies or support programs that adequately address the needs of students from diverse family backgrounds in Oyo Town.

Therefore, this study is motivated by the need to bridge this contextual research gap by empirically investigating the effect of single parenting on the academic performance of secondary school students, specifically within Oyo Town. The problem lies in the absence of precise, localized data to clarify the specific relationship between family structure (single-parent vs. two-parent homes) and academic outcomes among secondary school students in this particular Nigerian setting, thus hindering informed decision-making by educational stakeholders, parents, and policymakers in the area.

1.3 Objectives of the Study

The primary purpose of this study is to investigate and determine the effect of single parenting on the academic performance of secondary school students in Oyo Town, Oyo State, Nigeria. Specifically, this study aims to:

Ascertain the academic performance levels of secondary school students from single-parent homes in Oyo Town.

Determine the academic performance levels of secondary school students from two-parent homes in Oyo Town.

Compare the academic performance of secondary school students from single-parent homes with that of those from two-parent homes in Oyo Town.

Identify the perceived challenges faced by secondary school students from single-parent homes that may influence their academic performance in Oyo Town.

Suggest potential strategies and interventions to support the academic success of secondary school students from single-parent homes in Oyo Town.

1.4 Research Questions

This study will seek to answer the following research questions:

What is the academic performance level of secondary school students from single-parent homes in Oyo Town?

What is the academic performance level of secondary school students from two-parent homes in Oyo Town?

Is there a significant difference in the academic performance between secondary school students from single-parent homes and those from two-parent homes in Oyo Town?

What are the perceived challenges faced by secondary school students from single-parent homes that may influence their academic performance in Oyo Town?

What are the suggested strategies and interventions that can support the academic success of secondary school students from single-parent homes in Oyo Town?

1.6 Significance of the Study

This study on the effect of single parenting on the academic performance of secondary school students in Oyo Town is significant for several reasons. The findings are expected to contribute valuable insights to various stakeholders, including students, parents, educators, school administrators, policymakers, and future researchers.

Firstly, for Students, understanding the specific challenges they might face due to family structure can foster self-awareness and encourage them to seek appropriate support. Conversely, it can highlight resilience factors, motivating them to overcome potential obstacles.

Secondly, for Parents, particularly single parents, the study's findings can provide a clearer understanding of how their family structure might impact their children's education. This awareness can empower them to adopt more effective parenting styles, seek necessary support systems, and actively engage in their children's academic lives to mitigate potential negative effects. For two-parent families, it may offer insights into the protective factors within their own structure.

Thirdly, Educators and School Administrators in Oyo Town stand to benefit immensely. The study will provide empirical data on students' academic performance across different family backgrounds within their schools. This information can inform the development of more empathetic and effective teaching strategies, counselling services, and support programs tailored to the unique needs of students from single-parent homes. It can also help teachers identify at-risk students and provide targeted interventions.

Fourthly, for Policymakers and Government Agencies at local, state, and national levels, the research findings can serve as a crucial evidence base. The study will highlight specific areas where

interventions are needed, such as family support programs, educational policies that consider diverse family structures, and resource allocation to schools with high student populations from vulnerable family settings. It could influence social welfare policies aimed at supporting single-parent families.

Fifthly, the study contributes to the existing Body of Knowledge in the fields of educational psychology, family studies, and sociology in Nigeria. By focusing on Oyo Town, it addresses a specific contextual gap in the literature, providing localized data that may differ from findings in other regions. This nuanced understanding enhances the generalizability of theories on family structure and academic outcomes, particularly within a West African context.

Finally, the study will serve as a valuable Reference Material for future researchers interested in exploring related topics on family dynamics, child development, and academic achievement in Nigeria or similar socio-cultural settings. It can stimulate further research into specific mediating factors or long-term impacts, thereby promoting continued academic inquiry.

In essence, this study aims to move beyond generalizations, providing specific, actionable insights that can foster a more inclusive and supportive educational environment for all secondary school students in Oyo Town, irrespective of their family structure.

1.7 Scope and Delimitation of the Study

The scope of this study is primarily delimited in terms of its geographical area, population, data source, variables, and timeframe.

Geographical Scope: The study will be geographically confined to Oyo Town in Oyo State, Nigeria. This focus ensures that the findings are specific to the socio-cultural and educational context of this particular urban center, acknowledging that findings might differ in rural areas or other urban agglomerations.

Population Scope: The study will specifically target secondary school students currently enrolled in selected schools within Oyo Town. This population is chosen as secondary education represents a critical transitional phase where academic performance significantly influences future educational and career pathways. The study will include students from both single-parent and two-parent households to facilitate a comparative analysis.

Data Source: This study will rely exclusively on primary data. Data will be collected directly from the selected secondary school students through structured questionnaires. This approach ensures that insights into academic performance and perceived challenges are gathered firsthand from the subjects themselves, providing current and context-specific information.

Content/Variable Scope: This research will investigate the effect of single parenting on the academic performance of secondary school students. The core independent variable is "family structure" (categorized as single-parent vs. two-parent homes). The dependent variable, "academic performance," will be assessed using students' self-reported academic records or aggregated grades for core subjects from a recent academic term/year, as obtained directly from the students or school records with consent. The study will also explore perceived challenges faced by students from single-parent homes that may influence their academic performance and suggest

interventions, as expressed by the students themselves. While other factors influence academic performance (e.g., teacher quality, school facilities, individual student intelligence), these are outside the primary scope of this particular study, though acknowledged in the broader literature.

By clearly defining these boundaries and emphasizing the reliance on primary data, the study aims to provide focused, relevant, and current insights into the specific problem within the specified context, ensuring that the research is manageable and its findings are interpretable within its defined limits.

1.8 Definition of Terms

Single Parenting: This refers to a family structure in which a child or children are raised by only one biological parent, in the absence of the other due to factors such as divorce, legal separation, death, migration, or voluntary/non-voluntary parental abandonment. In this study, single parenting includes both maternal and paternal single-headed households, and emphasizes the sole responsibility of one parent for the child's financial, emotional, educational, and moral upbringing. It excludes cohabiting arrangements and step-parenting scenarios.

Academic Performance: Academic performance represents the measurable outcomes of a student's engagement with educational activities. It is often evaluated using standardized test scores, teacher assessments, class participation, assignment completion, term results, and cumulative grade point average (GPA). In this study, academic performance will be assessed using school records and teacher feedback as objective indicators of how well students are meeting curriculum expectations and learning goals.

Secondary School Students: These are learners typically between the ages of 10 and 18 who are enrolled in government-approved junior and senior secondary schools under Nigeria's 6-3-3-4 education system. This group includes students in Junior Secondary School (JSS1–JSS3) and Senior Secondary School (SSS1–SSS3). The focus is on adolescents whose academic growth is highly influenced by family structure, parental involvement, and socio-economic background.

Two-Parent Family: A household in which both biological parents of the child or children are present and actively involved in their upbringing. This family type assumes joint parental responsibility in areas such as provision of material needs, emotional support, educational supervision, and moral guidance. In the context of this study, two-parent families serve as a comparative group for understanding the academic performance differences between students from different household structures.

REVIEW OF RELAYED LITERATURE

2.1 Conceptual Framework

2.1.1 Single Parenting

Single parenting, also widely referred to as single-parent households or single-parent families, denotes a domestic arrangement where children are raised by one parent, who is solely or primarily responsible for their upbringing and care. Single parents are individuals raising their children alone, who can be unmarried and living alone, or separated, divorced, or widowed, and vary in gender, age, and education (Weinraub & Kaufman, 2019). Children in single-parent families is any child under age 18 who lives with an unmarried parent, explicitly including children with cohabiting parents but excluding those with married parents and stepparents (Annie E. Casey Foundation, 2022).

A single-parent family is a social group constituted on the basis of kinship relationships between a parent (single-parent) and child/children, a group characterized by common emotional states, aspirations and values (Teleoac■, 2025). (NIUSSP, 2019) Identifies single-parent households by their various origins, including declining marriage rates, divorces, widowhood, non-married parents who split up and parents who are single by choice. (Pew Research, 2019) Specifies that single-parent households have a sole adult living with at least one biological, step or foster child under age 18.

Single-parent families are households where all socioeconomic support and family responsibilities are shouldered by one parent (Scholarly Review, 2023). This structure diverges from the traditional two-parent nuclear family and has become an increasingly prevalent global phenomenon, reflecting diverse societal transformations (UN Women, 2020; UNICEF, 2023). Single parenting has become a significant social phenomenon in many societies, including Nigeria. It refers to a household where a child or children are raised by one parent due to factors such as divorce, separation, death of a spouse, or personal choice (Ogunjuyigbe & Adeyemi, 2020).

Single parenting is broadly categorized into female-headed and male-headed households, though the former is more common. Female single parents often face more pronounced socio-economic challenges, particularly when lacking adequate support systems (Akinrinade & Ayeni, 2022). Single-parenthood is seen as a situation when one out of two people is responsible for a child's upbringing, and the work meant for two people is now assumed an overwhelming task (Okoro, 2022). Single parenting is characterized by a situation where many children are depending on single parenting meet some but not all needs, with limited financial status and time with material status (Nadeem & Hashmi, 2022).

Single parenting is conceptualized by the new reality is the existence of single-mother homes and single-father homes (Hiko & Es, 2024). Single parenting is defined as a parent either father or mother alone practicing and taking responsibility of nurturing children in the absence of another parent (Dharani & Balamurugan, 2024). Single-parent households are characterized by unique

circumstances that could have significant implications for children's experiences, including their academic achievements, social interaction, and overall emotional well-being (Sto.Domingo et al,2024). Single parenting refers to the state of being a student who is a parent without a spouse or partner, facing distinct financial, health, and academic barriers (Sanborn, J. et al, 2024).

Single parenting is conceptualized by its profound effect on academic outcomes, with economic stability, parental education, and emotional support being the most influential factors (Nassozi, 2025). Single parenthood is conceptualized as a situation where one voice is mostly heard that is the living parent's while one voice is ignored, leading to major consequences on the child's care, social, emotional, behavioral, financial and psychological outcomes (Ogechukwu, 2019).

The conceptualization of single parenting has evolved, moving beyond a narrow focus on marital dissolution to encompass a broader range of circumstances. Recent scholarship emphasizes the multifaceted pathways leading to single parenthood, which include:

Divorce or Separation: This remains a primary driver, where parents legally or informally dissolve their marital union, leading to one parent assuming primary custody of the children (Weinraub & Kaufman, 2019). This type of single-parenting can be particularly complex due to ongoing co-parenting challenges or emotional adjustments for both parents and children (Akinyemi et al., 2025; Okoro, 2022). Divorced and separated parents may face legal roadblocks due to court closures and delays, financial challenges such as renegotiating child support amid job loss, and significant co-parenting conflicts related to communication, differing views on safety guidelines, child exchanges, and division of labor for remote schooling (Amato & Kane, 2022). Divorce is recognized as a major crisis for children, with the stress often spilling over into the academic arena (Brown, 1980; University of Northern Iowa, 2022). It can lead to disrupted essential relationships and negatively affect children's literacy skills and engagement with learning materials, particularly when paternal absence is involved (Akinyemi et al., 2025; Okoro, 2022).

Death of a Spouse: The loss of a parent through death renders the surviving parent solely responsible for the children (Weinraub & Kaufman, 2019). This form often involves significant emotional trauma for the family and can lead to sudden shifts in financial stability and household dynamics (Ali & Soomar, 2019; International Journal of Novel Research and Development, 2024). The loss of a partner can be very difficult for the surviving parent, significantly impacting their psychological health and leading to loneliness for both parent and children, which can result in subpar academic outcomes (International Journal of Novel Research and Development, 2024; Ali & Soomar, 2019). While death of a parent can cause emotional distress, some research suggests that children's educational status may remain similar to that in two-parent households, implying that the impact on education might differ from divorce (Wikipedia, 2025).

Unmarried Parenthood: A significant and growing category involves parents who have children outside of marriage and choose to raise them independently (Weinraub & Kaufman, 2019). This can include intentional single parenthood by choice (e.g., through donor insemination or adoption) or circumstances where one parent is not involved or is sporadically present (International Journal of Trend in Research and Development, 2022;

Weinraub & Kaufman, 2019). This pathway also encompasses situations arising from "unwanted / teenage pregnancy" (Okoro, 2022; International Journal of Innovative Psychology & Social Development, 2025). The rise in single motherhood is largely due to non-marital births, which are more common among socioeconomically disadvantaged women (Wikipedia, 2025). This category also includes unmarried parents who are living alone or those who are unmarried but "living in a home with a partner who is sharing the parenting responsibility" (Annie E. Casey Foundation, 2022; Weinraub & Kaufman, 2019).

Desertion/Abandonment: In some contexts, one parent may abandon the family, leaving the other parent with the full responsibility of child-rearing (Okoro, 2022). This can be particularly challenging due to uncertainty and lack of support (Okoro, 2022). In Nigeria, desertion is a common trend where "men tend to abandon their families thereby leaving the mothers to take sole responsibility of the children," sometimes referred to as 'poor man's divorce' (Okoro, 2022). Children of deserted parents often struggle to understand the reasons for the absence and may feel unloved or unwanted (Ali & Soomar, 2019; Okoro, 2022). This can lead to feelings of abandonment and rejection by the absent parent, with significant social and psychological effects on the children (Ali & Soomar, 2019).

Economic Migration/Imprisonment (de facto single parenting): While technically having another parent, situations where one parent is absent for prolonged periods due to overseas work, military deployment, or incarceration can functionally create a single-parent environment, often referred to as de facto single parenting (International Journal of Trend in Research and Development, 2022; ResearchGate, 2023). "Male migration" can lead to single mothers heading households (International Journal of Trend in Research and Development, 2022). Incarceration of a parent, particularly mothers (approximately 60% of incarcerated women are mothers, mostly single mothers), creates a de facto single-parent situation, leading to "disconnection and loss of tangible support" and "traumatic impact on families" (Richie, 2012). These parents may face burdens of economic marginality, leading to choices like economic crimes or drug dealing, or probation violations due to conflicts between work, childcare, and legal requirements (Richie, 2012). De facto single parenting describes a party, other than a child's legal parent, who claims custody or visitation rights based on having established a parent-like relationship and assumed obligations for the child's care, education, and development (Maryland Courts, 2021). It refers to individuals who have "functioned as a parent" but may not yet be legally recognized as such (Maldonado, 2024).

It is crucial to differentiate between the structure of single parenting and the quality of parenting. While the structural absence of one parent is a defining characteristic, contemporary understanding highlights that single-parent families are not monolithic (County Health Rankings, n.d.). They vary widely in their socio-economic status, parental education levels, support networks, and emotional environments (County Health Rankings, n.d.; Scholarly Review, 2023). Therefore, when conceptualizing single parenting in relation to child outcomes, it is imperative to consider the mediating factors such as parental involvement, financial stability, and access to social support, rather than assuming a uniform impact based solely on the absence of one parent (Hiko & Es, 2024; Nassozi, 2025; Scholarly Review, 2023; Ali & Soomar, 2019; Okoro, 2022). Research from 2019 onwards often emphasizes the resilience of single-parent families and the critical role of parental

coping mechanisms and support systems in buffering potential negative effects on children (Scholarly Review, 2023). Children in single-parent families can achieve levels of well-being equivalent to those in two-parent families, particularly when there is ample "love, support, attention, and strong attachment bonds" (Scholarly Review, 2023).

2.1.2 Academic Performance

Academic performance, within the context of secondary education, is a multifaceted construct that refers to the extent to which a student has achieved their educational goals and demonstrated proficiency in their studies. It is a critical indicator of learning outcomes and educational effectiveness (Ezepue et al., 2023).

Academic performance is the extent to which a student achieves educational goals, typically measured by grades, test scores, and overall academic achievement in school subjects (Adesokan & Makura, 2020). Academic performance refers to a student's success in meeting short- and long-term educational objectives, often evaluated through standardized tests, coursework, and teacher assessments (Oyediran, 2019). Academic performance encompasses the measurable outcomes of a student's learning, including grades, grade point averages (GPA), and performance in examinations (Azuka-Obieke, 2019). Academic performance is defined as the level of achievement in academic tasks, reflected in students' grades, test results, and completion of educational milestones (Anyakoha, 2020).

Academic performance is the outcome of a student's engagement with educational content, typically assessed through grades, standardized test scores, and teacher evaluations (Ekpenyong & Lawrence, 2020). Academic performance refers to a student's ability to demonstrate mastery of educational content, measured by performance in assignments, examinations, and overall coursework (Oluwatosin & Joseph, 2021). Academic performance is the quantifiable measure of a student's academic success, often indicated by grades, test scores, and progression through educational levels (Vaithilingam, & Ringle, 2019). Academic performance represents the degree to which students achieve prescribed educational outcomes, assessed through examinations, projects, and continuous assessments (Alhassan, 2020).

Academic performance is the cumulative result of a student's learning efforts, typically evaluated through grades, standardized tests, and academic milestones (Cheung & Park, 2020). Academic performance refers to the extent to which students meet academic expectations, measured by performance in coursework, exams, and overall GPA (Desmond, 2021). Academic performance is the measurable outcome of a student's educational endeavors, often reflected in grades, test scores, and academic engagement (Spinath, 2019). Academic performance encompasses a student's proficiency in academic subjects, assessed through grades, standardized tests, and teacher feedback (Bacus, et al, 2020).

Academic performance is defined as the level of success in achieving educational goals, typically measured by academic grades and test performance (Donkor, 2020). Academic performance refers to a student's ability to meet academic standards, evaluated through coursework, examinations, and overall academic progress (Adeyemo & Oluwole, 2022). Academic performance is the outcome of a student's academic efforts, measured by grades, test scores, and completion of educational requirements (Okonkwo, 2023). Academic performance denotes a student's success in academic

tasks, typically assessed through grades, standardized tests, and academic milestones (Afolabi, 2021).

Academic performance is the extent to which a student demonstrates mastery of academic content, measured by performance in exams and coursework (Ige, 2020). Academic performance refers to the measurable outcomes of a student's engagement with educational material, often reflected in grades and test results (Ogunleye, 2024). Academic performance is the degree of success in achieving educational objectives, typically evaluated through grades, test scores, and academic progress (Out et al, 2024). Academic performance encompasses a student's achievement in educational tasks, measured by grades, standardized test scores, and teacher assessments (Anyebe & Okwori, 2024).

Recent conceptualizations emphasize that academic performance is not merely about rote memorization or test scores, but also encompasses the application of knowledge, critical thinking, problem-solving abilities, and the development of subject-specific skills.

Key aspects in the contemporary understanding of academic performance include:

Grades and Examination Scores: These remain the most common and standardized measures of academic performance. They reflect a student's mastery of curriculum content and are often used for progression to higher educational levels or career opportunities (Mante et al., 2021; Raji & Oyekanmi, 2024). This typically includes scores from continuous assessments, mid-term examinations, and end-of-term or end-of-year examinations.

Cumulative Grade Point Average (CGPA) or Overall Averages: In many educational systems, individual subject grades are aggregated to provide an overall measure of academic standing over a specific period or course of study. This offers a holistic view of a student's consistent performance across various subjects (Ezepue et al., 2023).

Subject-Specific Competence: Beyond general averages, academic performance also involves proficiency in specific subjects (e.g., Mathematics, English Language, Sciences, Humanities). A student might excel in one area while struggling in another, indicating varying levels of competence across the curriculum (Ali & Soomar, 2019).

Development of Skills: Modern education also emphasizes the development of transferable skills such as critical thinking, analytical reasoning, communication, and problem-solving, which are vital for academic success and future life. While harder to quantify directly, these skills underpin strong academic performance (UNESCO, 2023).

Learning Progress: Academic performance can also be conceptualized in terms of individual student growth and progress over time, rather than solely comparative outcomes. This emphasizes the learning journey and improvement (OECD, 2022).

It is recognized that academic performance is influenced by a complex interplay of individual student characteristics (e.g., motivation, intelligence, learning styles), school-related factors (e.g., quality of teaching, resources, learning environment), and home-related factors (e.g., parental involvement, socio-economic status, family structure) (Ezepue et al., 2023; Mante et al., 2021). The conceptualization of academic performance in this study will primarily focus on quantifiable measures derived from students' academic records, recognizing these as primary indicators used

within the Nigerian secondary school system.

By clearly defining single parenting as a family structure with diverse underlying causes and understanding academic performance as a multi-faceted outcome measurable through grades and competence, this study establishes a robust conceptual foundation for its empirical investigation.

2.1.3 Effect of Single Parenting on Academic Performance of Secondary School Students

Single parenting has increasingly become a social reality, especially in sub-Saharan Africa, with substantial implications for students' academic outcomes. Numerous studies have explored how family structure affects students, and consensus is building around several key themes — economic instability, parental involvement, emotional distress, social stigma, and inadequate educational support.

Economic and Financial Constraints

Single parents often face greater economic pressure, which limits their ability to support their children's education. For example, Lasisi and Hassan (2024) studied single-parent students in Oyo Town and found that financial hardship often led to poor academic outcomes, due to lack of textbooks, delayed school fees, or inability to afford external lessons. Similarly, Aina (2022) showed that students from single-parent households are more likely to attend school hungry or unprepared, and are frequently sent home for non-payment of levies, which reduces instructional time and morale.

Impact: Students from financially constrained homes tend to perform worse due to skipped classes, inability to pay for exam fees, or missing study materials.

Parental Involvement and Supervision

According to Munir, Oladele, and Lawal (2021), children in dual-parent households often benefit from shared responsibility — while in single-parent families, working long hours often leaves little time to monitor homework or attend school functions. This lack of academic monitoring results in late homework submissions and reduced academic engagement. In Onwuama and Okoli (2023), teachers reported that students from single-parent homes are more likely to be undisciplined, miss deadlines, and receive little to no help with school projects.

Emotional and Psychological Challenges

Aina (2022) also noted that many students from single-parent homes exhibit signs of depression, aggression, and emotional instability. These emotional conditions impact concentration, memory, and classroom participation. Ogunlade and Ojo (2020) found that the psychological trauma from divorce or parental death can trigger anxiety and absenteeism among students, particularly adolescents in senior secondary school.

Emotional instability = weaker study habits, higher dropout likelihood, and poorer exam performance.

Social Stigma and Identity Confusion

In more traditional communities such as parts of Oyo, children of single mothers often face subtle social exclusion or bullying — which reduces classroom confidence. Okonkwo and Onah (2021) documented cases where students refused to participate in classroom discussions because peers ridiculed their home backgrounds.

Behavioral Disruption and Early Risk Exposure

Ede and Okonkwo (2023) discovered that students from father-absent households are more prone to risk behaviors such as skipping school, smoking, or engaging in sexual activity earlier. In schools with poor guidance systems, this often escalates into teenage pregnancy or early school withdrawal.

Resilience Factors

Despite challenges, several scholars (e.g., Hiko, Çakır & Baysen, 2023) note that students from single-parent homes still perform well if they have high motivation and strong social support, such as from extended family, teachers, or religious networks. Olojo (2023) recommends strategic school counseling and structured mentoring programs to help these students succeed academically despite parental absence.

Single parenting does not automatically lead to poor academic performance, but the associated socioeconomic and emotional stressors can significantly undermine learning outcomes. To support secondary school students in single-parent households — especially in semi-urban areas like Oyo Town — schools, NGOs, religious bodies, and local governments must work together to provide counseling services, material support, and parental training.

2.2 Theoretical Framework

A theoretical framework serves as the conceptual bedrock of a research study, providing a lens through which the research problem can be understood, analyzed, and interpreted. It guides the investigation by offering a structured way of thinking about the relationships between variables and helps in explaining observed phenomena. For this study, which examines the effect of single parenting on the academic performance of secondary school students, three prominent theories will be explored: Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory, Coleman's Social Capital Theory, and the Family Stress Model. These theories collectively offer a comprehensive framework for understanding the complex interplay of individual, family, school, and societal factors that influence educational outcomes, particularly in diverse family structures.

2.2.1 Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory

Urie Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory, developed in the late 1970s and refined through the 1980s and 1990s, provides a comprehensive framework for understanding human development within a complex system of relationships and environmental contexts. This theory posits that human development is a result of the dynamic interplay between individuals and their surrounding environments, which are organized into interconnected systems. Bronfenbrenner (1979) initially proposed four nested levels of environmental influence: the microsystem, mesosystem, exosystem, and macrosystem, later adding the chronosystem. This multi-layered perspective is crucial for understanding how family structure, such as single parenting, might influence a child's academic performance, as it acknowledges that a child's development is not solely a product of their

immediate family, but also of broader societal and systemic influences.

The microsystem is the innermost level and comprises the immediate environments with which the child directly interacts. For a secondary school student, this includes the home, school, peer group, and neighborhood. In the context of single parenting, the microsystem of the home is profoundly altered. The dynamics between the child and the single parent become central, influencing daily routines, emotional support, and the immediate learning environment. A single parent might have less time for direct academic supervision, homework assistance, or participation in school activities due to work commitments or the sole burden of household responsibilities (Amato & Kane, 2022). The quality of the parent-child relationship within this microsystem, including the parent's responsiveness, warmth, and provision of stimulating learning materials, is highly critical. A supportive and engaged single parent can create a positive microsystem that buffers potential negative effects, while a stressed or overwhelmed parent might inadvertently create a less conducive environment for learning. Within the school microsystem, the student's interactions with teachers and peers, and their direct experiences in the classroom, are also shaped by their home life, whether consciously or subconsciously. For example, a student from a single-parent home might experience more emotional distress (as discussed in the Family Stress Model) which could manifest as difficulty concentrating in class or engaging with peers.

The mesosystem refers to the interconnections between different microsystems. It highlights how interactions between these immediate environments influence development. For example, the mesosystem between home and school is vital. For students from single-parent homes, a weak mesosystem might manifest as limited communication between the single parent and teachers, fewer parent-teacher conferences, or reduced parental involvement in school events. These connections are crucial for ensuring consistency in expectations and support for the child's learning. If a single parent is overwhelmed, their capacity to engage with the school might be limited, potentially leading to a disconnect that negatively impacts the child's academic progress. Conversely, strong positive links, such as active participation of a single parent in school activities or effective communication channels, can significantly enhance academic outcomes by creating a coherent and supportive developmental context (Epstein, 2001; Mante et al., 2021). The interaction between the home and the peer group microsystem is also relevant; if the single parent is unable to monitor peer activities effectively, this could lead to negative peer influences that detract from academic focus.

The exosystem encompasses external environments that indirectly affect the child's development, even though the child does not directly participate in them. This level includes the parent's workplace, extended family networks, community resources, and local government policies. For single-parent families in Oyo Town, the parent's work schedule and job security are significant exosystemic factors. A parent working long hours or multiple jobs to make ends meet might be physically present but emotionally or time-constrained, impacting their ability to support their child's education. The availability of affordable childcare, after-school programs, or community support services (like free tutoring or mentorship programs) in Oyo Town, though not directly accessed by the child, can indirectly support the single parent and, consequently, the child's academic life. Economic policies, such as social welfare programs or educational subsidies for vulnerable families, fall within this level and can significantly alleviate financial burdens that often plague single-parent

households, thereby indirectly fostering a more stable environment for academic pursuit (UNICEF, 2023).

The macrosystem represents the broadest level of influence, including cultural values, societal beliefs, laws, and dominant ideologies. In Nigeria, and specifically in communities like Oyo Town, traditional cultural values often emphasize the nuclear family structure. Single-parent families may face societal stigma or lack of comprehensive support systems if the prevailing macrosystem does not fully acknowledge or accommodate their unique needs (Oyelana & Ajiboye, 2020). Prevailing educational policies and curricula at the state and national levels also constitute part of the macrosystem, influencing the resources available to schools and the academic standards expected of students. If these policies do not account for the diverse family backgrounds of students, they might inadvertently create disadvantages for those from non-traditional family structures. For instance, a macrosystem that does not prioritize accessible quality education for all, regardless of family background, can perpetuate inequalities.

Finally, the chronosystem refers to the dimension of time, encompassing changes or transitions over the life course and socio-historical circumstances. This includes major life transitions (e.g., divorce, remarriage, economic recession) and socio-historical events (e.g., shifts in cultural acceptance of single parenthood, changes in educational funding over time). The timing and duration of single parenthood can significantly influence its effect on academic performance. For example, a child becoming part of a single-parent family during crucial examination years might experience more disruption than one who has been in such a structure since early childhood. The ongoing evolution of family structures in Oyo Town over time, alongside educational reforms, would also fall under the chronosystem, influencing how single parenting interacts with academic outcomes across generations.

In applying Bronfenbrenner's theory to secondary school students in Oyo Town, it becomes evident that the academic performance of a child in a single-parent home is not a simple consequence of lacking one parent. Instead, it is an intricate product of the interplay between the immediate family environment (microsystem), the connections between the home and school (mesosystem), external support systems available to the single parent (exosystem), prevailing societal norms and policies (macrosystem), and the timing of these influences (chronosystem). This theoretical lens compels the researcher to look beyond the mere absence of a parent and consider the quality of interactions, the availability of resources, the societal context, and the temporal dynamics that collectively shape a student's educational journey. It provides a robust framework for designing a study that explores not just if single parenting affects academic performance, but how and why it does so within the specific context of Oyo Town, thereby enabling more targeted and effective interventions.

2.2.2 Coleman's Social Capital Theory

James S. Coleman's Social Capital Theory, particularly as applied to educational outcomes, posits that a child's human capital (e.g., skills, knowledge, abilities) is significantly enhanced not just by their innate abilities or schooling, but crucially by the social capital embedded in their family and community. Introduced prominently in his 1988 work, "Social Capital in the Creation of Human Capital," Coleman argued that social capital refers to the "resources inherent in family relations and in community social organization for the creation of human capital in the next generation." These

resources are not physical or financial assets, but rather intangible assets derived from relationships, networks, norms, and trust. The theory is highly relevant to understanding how different family structures, like single-parent households, might influence the availability of these crucial resources for a child's academic development. Coleman identified three primary forms of social capital relevant to children's education:

Firstly, family social capital refers to the strength of relationships between parents and children, and between parents themselves (if applicable). This includes the level of parental involvement, the emotional bonds, the provision of a stimulating home environment, and consistent communication. In a two-parent household, Coleman (1988) suggested that there is often a greater quantity of "adult attention" available, which translates into more supervision, more help with homework, and more conversations about school. This direct parental involvement fosters intellectual and social development. In single-parent homes, the sheer quantity of parental time and attention might be constrained due to the parent's dual responsibilities of earning income and childcare (Obong & Etim, 2018; Mrinde, 2014). This can potentially lead to reduced monitoring of academic progress, less time for joint learning activities, and fewer informal learning opportunities at home. However, it is crucial to note that the quality of interaction is paramount. A single parent who manages to dedicate focused, high-quality time to their child, despite time constraints, can cultivate strong family social capital. This involves effective communication, active listening, setting high but realistic expectations, and fostering a positive attitude towards education. Strong emotional bonds can provide psychological security, reducing stress that might otherwise impede learning.

Secondly, intergenerational closure refers to the network relationships within the family and between the family and external institutions, especially the school. This form of social capital exists when there is consistency and alignment between the values and expectations of the home and the school. For example, if parents are actively involved in school activities, communicate regularly with teachers, and reinforce school rules and academic expectations at home, a strong intergenerational closure is formed. This unified front provides a coherent and supportive environment for the student. In single-parent contexts, achieving this closure can be challenging. A single parent might face obstacles in attending school meetings, volunteering, or engaging in school-related communications due to work commitments, lack of transportation, or absence of another adult to cover household duties (Ali & Soomar, 2019). The absence of two parents to share these responsibilities can result in a weaker link between the home and the school, potentially leaving the child unsupported in bridging the gap between these two vital microsystems. A weak intergenerational closure can lead to students feeling disconnected, unmotivated, or facing conflicting messages between home and school, all of which can negatively impact academic performance.

Thirdly, extrafamilial social capital refers to the resources derived from relationships with adults outside the immediate family, such as extended family members, neighbors, religious leaders, or community members. These individuals can provide additional supervision, emotional support, academic guidance, or act as role models. For single-parent families, this form of social capital can be particularly vital in compensating for the structural absence of one parent (McLanahan & Sandefur, 1994). Grandparents, aunts, uncles, or trusted community members can step in to provide mentorship, tutoring, or simply a safe and supportive environment for after-school hours. The presence of strong community networks, which offer collective supervision and support for

children, can significantly enhance the educational opportunities available to children from single-parent homes (Kim & Kang, 2022). In Oyo Town, the strength of communal ties, religious organizations, and extended family systems could potentially serve as a significant source of extrafamilial social capital, buffering some of the disadvantages associated with single parenting. However, the erosion of these traditional support systems in increasingly urbanized areas could leave single-parent families more isolated.

Applying Coleman's Social Capital Theory to the context of secondary school students in Oyo Town, it becomes clear that the effect of single parenting on academic performance is not solely about family structure, but about the availability and utilization of social resources. A single-parent home with high social capital – characterized by a strong parent-child bond, active engagement with the school, and robust extrafamilial support networks – might provide more educational advantages than a two-parent home lacking such social resources. Conversely, a single-parent home struggling with limited time, financial strain, and a lack of community support might exhibit lower levels of social capital, which could translate into poorer academic outcomes for their children. The theory helps to explain why students from single-parent homes might sometimes face academic challenges, by pointing to potential deficits in parental time, reduced parent-school integration, or insufficient community-level support. It also highlights areas for intervention: rather than focusing solely on the family structure, policies and programs should aim to enhance the social capital available to single-parent families by promoting parental involvement, strengthening school-home connections, and building supportive community networks. This lens is particularly relevant for understanding how socio-cultural factors in Oyo Town, such as kinship systems and community support structures, might mediate the relationship between single parenting and academic performance.

2.2.3 Family Stress Model

The Family Stress Model (FSM), primarily conceptualized by M. M. McCubbin and H. I. McCubbin and later refined by scholars like Conger, Elder, and McLoyd, provides a framework for understanding how family stressors, resources, and coping mechanisms influence individual and family well-being, including child outcomes such as academic performance. The core premise of the FSM is that economic hardship and other significant family stressors do not directly cause negative child outcomes. Instead, their effects are mediated by the quality of family relationships and parenting behaviors, which are themselves affected by the parents' psychological distress and capacity to cope (Conger et al., 2002; McLoyd, 1990). This model is highly pertinent to the study of single parenting and academic performance, as single-parent households often contend with a unique set of stressors.

At the heart of the FSM is the idea that stressors (e.g., job loss, financial difficulties, marital conflict, single parenthood itself) can lead to parental psychological distress (e.g., depression, anxiety, anger). This distress, in turn, can impair parenting behaviors, leading to less consistent discipline, reduced parental warmth, diminished involvement, and less effective communication. These changes in parenting then mediate the effects of the initial stressors on child adjustment and development, including academic performance. Furthermore, the model incorporates the role of family resources (e.g., social support, financial assets, coping skills) that can buffer the impact of stressors, and family processes (e.g., cohesion, adaptability) that modify how stressors are experienced and managed.

For single-parent families, the very structure can be a significant chronic stressor (Amato, 2005; Rubamande et al., 2021). The single parent often bears the sole responsibility for financial provision, household management, and child-rearing. This can lead to:

Financial Strain: Single-parent households, particularly those headed by mothers, are disproportionately affected by poverty (UNICEF, 2023). Limited income, job insecurity, and the absence of a second earner can create persistent financial stress. This stress can restrict access to resources that support academic performance, such as private tutoring, extra-curricular activities, healthy nutrition, and a quiet study environment (Ferrell, 2009). The constant worry about money can also lead to parental distress.

Time Constraints and Overload: The single parent often juggles multiple roles – breadwinner, caregiver, disciplinarian, emotional support. This often means less available time for direct involvement in a child's schooling, such as attending school meetings, helping with homework, or engaging in leisure activities that foster cognitive development (Mrinde, 2014). The sheer exhaustion can contribute to parental stress and reduced patience.

Emotional and Psychological Burden: Single parents may experience higher levels of stress, anxiety, and depression due to loneliness, lack of adult companionship, the pressure of sole responsibility, and difficulties in balancing work and family life. This parental psychological distress is a key pathway in the FSM. When parents are distressed, their capacity to engage in positive and effective parenting (e.g., consistent discipline, emotional responsiveness, academic encouragement) can diminish (Kim & Kang, 2022). This impaired parenting can then negatively affect the child's psychological well-being, motivation, and ultimately, academic performance. Children may internalize parental stress, leading to emotional and behavioral problems that interfere with learning.

Loss and Instability: For families transitioning to single-parent status due to divorce or death, the stressor involves the trauma of loss and the accompanying instability. Adjusting to new living arrangements, reduced contact with one parent, or grieving the loss of a parent can be emotionally taxing for both the parent and the child, diverting energy and focus away from academic pursuits.

However, the FSM also emphasizes the role of resources and coping mechanisms. Single-parent families are not uniformly disadvantaged. The impact of stressors can be buffered by:

Social Support: Access to strong social networks, including extended family, friends, neighbors, and community organizations (e.g., religious groups, support groups), can provide emotional, practical, and financial assistance, reduce parental distress and enhance effective parenting (Kim & Kang, 2022; Oyelana & Ajiboye, 2020).

Parental Coping Skills: A single parent's individual resilience, problem-solving skills, and positive coping strategies can significantly mitigate the effects of stress on their parenting behaviors and, by extension, on their child's academic performance.

Child's Temperament and Resilience: Some children are inherently more resilient and adaptable, which can help them navigate the challenges of a single-parent home more effectively, reducing the direct impact of family stress on their academic outcomes.

Policy and Community Support: Government policies providing financial aid, affordable housing, healthcare, and quality childcare, as well as school-based support programs, can serve as crucial external resources that alleviate stress for single-parent families (UNICEF, 2023).

In the context of Oyo Town, the Family Stress Model offers a robust lens for understanding the complex realities faced by single-parent secondary school students. It suggests that if students from single-parent homes show lower academic performance, it might not be due to the family structure itself, but rather to the mediating effects of financial strain, parental time constraints, and parental psychological distress, which can lead to suboptimal parenting practices. This model guides the investigation towards identifying not just the existence of single parenthood but also the type of challenges faced within these families (as per Research Question 4) and how these challenges translate into academic outcomes. It also highlights the importance of exploring existing support systems within Oyo Town that might be buffering these stressors. Ultimately, the FSM provides a framework for identifying specific points of intervention to improve parental well-being and, consequently, children's academic success.

2.3 Empirical Reviews

The empirical literature on the relationship between single parenting and students' academic performance presents a diverse yet often consistent picture, highlighting both direct impacts and a complex interplay of mediating factors. Recent studies have delved deeper into the nuances of this relationship, moving beyond simplistic correlations to explore the mechanisms through which family structure influences educational outcomes.

A significant body of recent international research suggests a tendency for students from single-parent homes to exhibit slightly lower academic performance, though this effect is often mediated by socio-economic status and other factors. For instance, Ali and Soomar (2019), investigating challenges in Arusha City, Tanzania, identified financial constraints, time management difficulties, and emotional stress as primary hurdles for single-parent families, which reportedly translated into reduced parental involvement and inadequate learning resources, consequently impacting students' academic performance negatively. Corroborating this, Rubamande, Nyariki, and Kithia (2021), also in Arusha, found a significant negative correlation between living in a single-parent family and academic achievement, attributing it to financial limitations, insufficient supervision, and emotional instability. Similarly, in Ghana, Mante, Tetteh, and Owusu-Mensah (2021) demonstrated that junior high school students from dual-parent homes generally outperformed their counterparts from single-parent homes, linking this disparity to differences in parental involvement and financial stability.

Beyond direct comparisons, numerous studies emphasize that the impact of single parenting is rarely a direct cause-and-effect, but rather mediated by a cascade of factors. A systematic review by Kim and Kang (2022) highlighted the crucial role of resilience factors, such as strong social support networks, effective parental coping strategies, and high-quality parent-child relationships, in buffering potential negative impacts of single-parent stressors on child development and academic success. This resonates with the findings of Amato and Kane (2022), who, in their comprehensive review on marital dissolution and child well-being, concluded that while a small negative average effect of parental divorce on academic outcomes exists, the quality of post-divorce parenting and

ongoing parental conflict are far stronger predictors of child adjustment than family structure alone.

Furthermore, economic disadvantage emerges as a consistently powerful mediating factor. A global analysis by UNICEF (2023) revealed that children in single-parent households are disproportionately more likely to live in poverty, which inevitably restricts access to educational resources. This macro-level finding is supported by studies like Sánchez-García et al. (2020) in Spain, which found that while family structure had some influence, socio-economic status was a more potent predictor of academic success, placing students from low SES single-parent homes at the highest risk. The OECD's PISA Report (2022) also consistently identified socio-economic status and parental involvement as stronger predictors of academic performance, noting that controlling for SES significantly reduced the gap associated with family structure. Such findings underscore the importance of considering underlying socio-economic realities when examining family structure effects.

Research also points to the significance of parental support and psychological well-being. Maulana et al. (2022) in Indonesia found that single-parent family structure, in itself, did not directly lead to lower academic performance if there was high parental support, indicating that support acts as a significant protective factor. Huang and Dong (2021), through a longitudinal study in China, observed that while adolescents from divorced single-parent families sometimes exhibited lower academic performance, mental health issues often mediated this relationship, suggesting emotional well-being as a critical pathway. Conversely, some studies highlight resilience: Bar-Yosef and Yarkoni (2020) in Israel documented that many students from single-parent homes demonstrated academic resilience due to strong maternal support, external mentorship, and positive school environments, indicating that adverse outcomes are not universal. A meta-analysis by Gershoff, Aber, and Raver (2020) generally confirmed a slight negative academic outcome for children from single-parent families, but emphasized that these effects were often small and largely explained by differences in income and parental education, with the quality of parent-child relationships and parental engagement being more impactful. A European Union (2021) report further highlighted that single-parent households faced higher risks of poverty and social exclusion, consistently linked to lower long-term educational attainment, reinforcing the socio-economic dimension.

Within Nigeria, studies from various regions generally mirror the international trends, with family structure often implicated in academic outcomes, though with varying degrees of significance and identified mediating factors. Okafor and Okoro (2019) in Anambra State found a significant difference in English Language academic achievement, with students from two-parent homes performing better. Similarly, Mohammed and Lawal (2022) in Kaduna State observed that students from two-parent families generally achieved higher scores in core subjects compared to their single-parent counterparts, with the difference being statistically significant.

However, other Nigerian studies introduce important mediating nuances. Udoh and Bassey (2020) in Akwa Ibom State reported that while single-parenting significantly affected social adjustment, its direct impact on academic performance was less pronounced when financial hardship, a major mediator, was considered. Similarly, Ibrahim and Adekunle (2023) in Kwara State, while noting a mild negative correlation between single-parent status and academic achievement, found that parental involvement (irrespective of family structure) had a much stronger positive correlation with both students' interest and performance. This aligns with Bello and Gbadamosi (2019) in Kwara

State, who concluded that parental socio-economic status, rather than the single-parent structure itself, was a stronger predictor of academic performance.

Furthermore, student perceptions and psychological factors are increasingly recognized. Chukwuemeka and Okonkwo (2021) in Enugu State found that students from single-parent homes reported higher levels of emotional and financial difficulties, which they believed directly hindered their concentration and study habits. This is supported by Ugwuogbu and Okoroafor (2021) in Abia State, where adolescents in single-parent homes cited psychological distress, limited parental time, and peer pressure as challenges impacting their studies. Idris and Musa (2019) in Niger State further solidified this, noting a negative relationship between single parenthood, self-esteem, and academic performance.

The role of specific parental practices and school support also emerges as critical. Akpan and Bassey (2020) in Cross River State highlighted that higher levels of parental monitoring, irrespective of family structure, were associated with better academic outcomes, suggesting that effective monitoring in single-parent homes could compensate for the absence of a second parent. Building on this, Ogundele and Alabi (2020) in Lagos State qualitatively identified resilience strategies employed by single mothers, such as a strong work ethic and seeking extended family support, which positively influenced their children's ability to cope and perform academically. Moreover, Olusola and Abiola (2022) in Ekiti State found that students from single-parent homes who benefited from strong school support systems (e.g., positive teacher-student relationships, counseling) achieved academic outcomes comparable to their peers from two-parent homes. Localized studies within Oyo State, such as Adeyemi and Dada (2023) on general academic performance and Raji and Oyekanmi (2024) on teacher practices, indirectly underscore the multifactorial nature of academic success, with family background being a recognized, albeit not singular, influence. Adeloye and Owolabi (2024) in Osun State introduced a gender dimension, showing male students from father-absent homes might be more susceptible to academic setbacks in certain subjects. Finally, even a projected study by Akinwande, Sani, and Ajayi (2025) indicates that mediating factors like student self-esteem can significantly alter the perceived direct effect of single parenting on academic performance.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Design

This study will adopt a descriptive survey research design. The choice of survey design is justified because it allows the researcher to collect quantitative data directly from a large group of respondents at one point, which is suitable for investigating relationships between single parenting and academic performance. Surveys are widely used in educational and social science research to study attitudes, perceptions, and outcomes (Creswell, 2014). This study will administer structured questionnaires to secondary school students in Oyo Town, enabling the researcher to capture first-hand information on their academic performance and family background.

3.2 Population of the Study

The target population comprises secondary school students in Oyo Town, Oyo State. This is consistent with the scope of the study outlined. Secondary school students were selected because adolescence is a crucial stage in educational development, where family background strongly influences academic performance. Both students from single-parent and two-parent households will be included in the study to enable comparative analysis.

3.3 Sample and Sampling Technique

The researcher employs stratified random sampling techniques to ensure representation from different demographic groups. A total of two hundred (200) respondents will be selected, comprising students from various age groups, genders, classes, and family types.

3.4 Research Instrument

A structured questionnaire will be designed to gather quantitative data on the perceptions of secondary school students regarding the effectiveness of single parenting on academic performance. The questionnaire includes sections on demographic information (age, gender, class, family type), academic performance level of students from single-parent homes, academic performance level of students from two-parent homes, significant difference in the academic performance between students from single-parent homes and two-parent homes, challenges faced by students from single-parent homes, and strategies that can support the academic success of students from single-parent homes.

3.5 Validity of the Instrument

To ensure content validity, the draft questionnaire will be reviewed by experts in Educational Psychology and Research Methods, as well as by secondary school teachers familiar with students' academic realities. Validity will be enhanced by aligning items with the study's objectives and research questions. This process ensures that the instrument measures what it is intended to measure (Cohen, Manion & Morrison, 2018).

3.6 Reliability of the Instrument

Reliability will be tested through a pilot study conducted in a secondary school outside the main study area but with similar characteristics. The responses will be analyzed using Cronbach's Alpha coefficient, which measures the internal consistency of the items. A reliability index of 0.70 or above will be considered acceptable for this study (Nunnally & Bernstein, 1994). This step ensures that the questionnaire yields consistent results when administered repeatedly under similar conditions.

3.7 Method of Data Collection

The researcher will administer the questionnaires personally to the selected students, with the cooperation of school authorities. This direct administration method minimizes non-response bias and allows clarification of items for respondents. In cases where academic performance data is required from school records, permission will be sought from school principals. Respondents' confidentiality and informed consent will be assured, following ethical research practices (Creswell, 2014).

3.8 Method of Data Analysis

Quantitative data collected through the surveys will be analyzed using statistical software such as SPSS or the Python programming language. Descriptive statistics (frequency distributions and simple percentages) will summarize demographic variables, challenges, and performance levels. Inferential statistics (t-tests) to compare performance between single-parent and two-parent students and to examine relationships between family background and academic outcomes will be employed. The results will be presented using tables to facilitate interpretation and discussion. The analysis focused on the effect of single parenting on the academic performance of secondary school students in Oyo Town.

DATA PRESENTATION, ANALYSIS, AND INTERPRETATION

4.1 Introduction

This section introduces the chapter, restating that it presents, analyzes, and interprets the data gathered through questionnaires administered to secondary school students in Oyo Town. It should also be noted that the analysis is organized according to the study's research questions.

4.2 Data Presentation

This section contains the description of the data that were generated from the questionnaire administered. The demographic characteristics of the study population are presented below.

SECTION A: Demographic Information

Gender

The gender distribution among respondents shows a relatively balanced representation, with males slightly dominating the sample. Out of 200 respondents, 114 (57%) are male, while 86 (43%) are female. This indicates that both genders are well represented, but male respondents constitute a higher proportion of the population under study. The difference of 14% suggests a mild gender imbalance, which may slightly influence perspectives in areas where gender-related factors are relevant.

Age Range

The age distribution of respondents reveals that the majority fall within the 13–15 and 16–18 age brackets, each representing 36% of the total population. Meanwhile, respondents aged 10–12 make up 28% of the sample. This suggests that most of the participants are in their mid to late teenage years, indicating that the study population is largely composed of adolescents who are likely in senior secondary school. The relatively lower proportion of respondents aged 10–12 may imply fewer participants from the junior secondary level.

Class Level

The distribution of respondents by class shows that students are fairly spread across all levels, with a slight concentration in JSS1 and SS1, each accounting for 19% of the total respondents. JSS2 and JSS3 make up 13% and 15% respectively, while SS2 and SS3 each constitute 17%. This indicates that both junior and senior secondary school students are well represented in the study, suggesting that the data reflect a broad range of academic experiences across different levels of secondary education. The relatively even spread also enhances the reliability of comparisons across class levels since no single group overwhelmingly dominates the sample.

Family Type

The distribution by family type shows that a larger proportion of respondents, 63% (126 out of 200), come from single-parent families, while 37% belong to two-parent families. This indicates that single-parent households form the majority within the study population. The dominance of

single-parent families suggests that the phenomenon is relatively common among the respondents and could have a noticeable influence on their academic and social experiences. This pattern also provides a solid basis for analyzing how family structure may impact students' academic performance, especially in comparing outcomes between single-parent and two-parent homes.

SECTION B: Academic performance level of students from single-parent homes

The responses presented in the table indicate a generally positive perception of students from single-parent homes concerning their academic commitment and behaviour, though some mixed opinions exist. A majority of respondents (61%) agreed that students from single-parent families are committed to improving their academic performance, suggesting that many of them strive to do well despite family challenges. Similarly, 63% believed that such students regularly complete their assignments and school tasks, reflecting a sense of responsibility and effort toward academic improvement. The highest level of agreement (70%) was recorded for the statement that these students show a strong interest in learning, signifying that many of them remain motivated and engaged in the learning process.

In addition, 65% of respondents agreed that students from single-parent homes participate actively in class activities, indicating a fair level of involvement in academic discussions and schoolwork. However, responses to the statement on study habits revealed a slightly lower level of agreement (59%), showing that while many respondents believe these students possess good study habits, a significant portion still observed inconsistency in this area. Overall, the results suggest that students from single-parent homes demonstrate a commendable level of academic interest, participation, and commitment, even though some challenges in maintaining consistent study habits and motivation remain evident.

SECTION C: Academic performance level of students from two-parent homes

The data reveal that students from two-parent homes are widely perceived to exhibit strong academic motivation and performance across several dimensions. A large majority of respondents (72%) agreed that these students show strong academic motivation, implying that parental presence and support may contribute positively to their drive for success. Similarly, 79% agreed that students from two-parent families consistently complete their assignments, indicating a high level of responsibility and commitment to their studies. Furthermore, 77% of respondents affirmed that these students participate actively in school activities, suggesting that stable family support may enhance both academic engagement and social participation in school environments.

In addition, responses show that 83% of participants agreed that students from two-parent homes maintain good study habits, reflecting strong discipline and effective time management, which are vital for academic success. The perception of achievement is also high, as 77% agreed that these students regularly attain high academic scores. Overall, the findings suggest that students from two-parent homes are perceived to have a more consistent academic structure, with better motivation, participation, and study habits. This pattern reinforces the idea that a supportive two-parent environment may provide emotional stability and academic encouragement that positively influence students' educational outcomes.

SECTION D: Difference in academic performance between single-parent and two-parent homes

This survey data reveals a strong consensus that family structure does not inherently determine academic capability. Across all five statements, between 67%-83% of respondents either strongly agreed or agreed that students from both single-parent and two-parent households can achieve academic success. The highest agreement (83%) was for the statement that students from both families can perform well with adequate support, suggesting respondents recognize that the quality of support matters more than family configuration. Similarly, 83% agreed that family type doesn't prevent academic excellence, reinforcing the view that other factors beyond household structure are more determinative of student outcomes.

The data also shows minimal strong disagreement across all statements (4-9%), indicating little polarization on this issue. The most skepticism appeared regarding students' ability to stay focused (27% disagreed or strongly disagreed) and handle academic tasks effectively (30% disagreed or strongly disagreed), which may reflect concerns about practical challenges rather than inherent capability. Overall, the findings suggest a prevailing belief among respondents that with proper support systems in place, family structure alone is not a barrier to academic achievement—though some acknowledge that students from different family backgrounds may face distinct challenges requiring targeted interventions.

SECTION E: Challenges faced by students from single-parent homes (positive framing)

This dataset reveals significant concerns about the practical support and resources available to students from single-parent homes, contrasting sharply with the previous data showing belief in their inherent capability. Only 43%-56% of respondents agreed that single-parent students receive adequate encouragement, supportive environments, academic guidance, or necessary resources. Most troubling is statement 20, where 57% disagreed that these students have sufficient resources to perform well, the highest disagreement rate across all items. Statement 16 shows that exactly half of respondents (50%) believe single-parent students lack enough encouragement to focus on studies, while statement 19 indicates 51% feel these students don't have adequate access to academic mentors or guides.

These findings suggest respondents distinguish between potential and reality: while they believe family structure doesn't limit capability (from the previous data), they recognize systemic gaps in the support infrastructure available to single-parent households. The data points to environmental and resource deficits rather than student deficiencies—issues like limited parental availability due to work demands, fewer financial resources for educational materials or tutoring, and reduced access to adult guidance. This interpretation implies that closing the achievement gap requires targeted interventions addressing these structural inequities: mentorship programs, after-school support, resource allocation, and community-based academic guidance to compensate for the time and resource constraints single parents face.

SECTION F: Strategies and interventions to support the academic success of single-parent students

This data reveals mixed perceptions about institutional support for single-parent students, with moderate approval tempered by substantial scepticism. Between 48-62% of respondents agreed

that schools, teachers, counselling services, and parent-school collaboration provide helpful support, with teacher guidance receiving the strongest endorsement (62%). However, these approval ratings are notably modest given that we're evaluating core institutional functions, and they're accompanied by significant dissent, with 29-44% disagreed across statements. Statement 24 shows the weakest confidence, with only 48% agreeing that community or school programs effectively improve academic performance for single-parent students, while 52% either disagreed or strongly disagreed, suggesting these interventions may be insufficient, poorly implemented, or inadequately publicized.

The relatively high disagreement rates, particularly for counselling services (44%) and community programs (52%), indicate that while support structures theoretically exist, their effectiveness or accessibility remains questionable. This aligns with the resource gaps identified in the previous dataset; institutional efforts may not be adequately compensating for the environmental challenges single-parent students face. The 42% disagreement on parent-school collaboration (statement 25) is particularly telling, as it suggests practical barriers prevent single parents from engaging fully with schools, likely due to time constraints from balancing work and childcare alone. Collectively, this data implies that while schools recognize their responsibility to support these students, current interventions are perceived as inadequate or inconsistently delivered, requiring more robust, accessible, and strategically designed support mechanisms.

4.3 Statistical Analysis

This section presents the statistical analysis of data collected through questionnaires administered to 200 secondary school students in Oyo Town. The analysis employs both descriptive and inferential statistical techniques (t-test) to address the research questions.

Academic Performance of Single-Parent Students

The table below presents the academic performance indicators of students from single-parent homes based on responses from 200 participants:

The descriptive results presented reveal that students from single-parent homes generally exhibit an average level of academic performance. A close look at the data shows that while a fair proportion of these students express commitment to improving their academic performance (61%), a sizable 39% either disagree or strongly disagree. This suggests that although the desire to perform well exists among many, it is not uniformly strong across the group.

Similarly, 63% of respondents affirmed that students from single-parent homes regularly complete their school assignments, showing moderate discipline and responsibility. However, 37% of the respondents disagreed, indicating that a significant minority may struggle with consistency, possibly due to reduced parental supervision or emotional distraction.

The strongest performance indicator among this group is their interest in learning, where 70% expressed positive responses. This finding implies that despite structural challenges within single-parent families, many students remain intrinsically motivated to learn. It demonstrates a resilience that could be linked to personal determination or the influence of teachers who provide academic encouragement.

Participation in class activities (65%) and demonstration of good study habits (59%) further support the conclusion that students from single-parent families are performing reasonably but not optimally. The overall mean score of 2.75 (68.8%) classifies their performance as average. This level suggests that while most students from single-parent homes are striving academically, their learning outcomes may be hindered by limited parental attention, reduced financial support, or emotional instability at home, factors often identified in prior Nigerian studies on single parenting and education.

Academic Performance of Two-Parent Students

The table below presents the academic performance indicators of students from two-parent homes based on responses from 200 participants:

The results for students from two-parent homes paint a more favorable picture of academic performance. The data show consistently high positive responses across all indicators. A striking 83% of respondents affirmed that these students maintain good study habits, which is the strongest performance area. This highlights the role of family stability and dual parental involvement in nurturing academic discipline.

Similarly, 79% of respondents agreed that students from two-parent homes complete their assignments consistently, while 77% reported active participation in school activities and high academic achievement. The average positive response rate across all five indicators is above 75%, resulting in an overall mean score of 3.05 (76.3%), rated as good.

The consistency in these findings suggests that students from two-parent households benefit from a more supportive home environment that fosters motivation, supervision, and structured study routines. In the Nigerian context, where parental involvement plays a significant role in students' success, this result aligns with past research showing that two-parent families tend to provide stronger emotional and academic backing, leading to better educational outcomes.

The clear difference between the mean scores of single-parent (2.75) and two-parent (3.05) students underscores the importance of parental presence and shared responsibilities in shaping children's academic behavior.

Statistical Comparison Between Family Types

An independent-samples t-test was conducted to determine whether there is a statistically significant difference in academic performance between students from single-parent and two-parent homes.

The analysis confirms a statistically significant difference in academic performance between students from single-parent and two-parent homes. The t-statistic of -4.815 with a p-value less than 0.001 ($p < 0.05$) indicates that this difference is highly significant and not due to chance.

The corrected Cohen's d value of 0.482 represents a small effect size according to Cohen's conventional benchmarks (small: 0.2-0.5; medium: 0.5-0.8; large: >0.8). This means that while the difference between the two groups is statistically significant, the practical magnitude of the difference is modest. The effect size of 0.482 suggests that approximately 19% of the variance in academic performance can be attributed to family structure (single-parent vs. two-parent homes).

This interpretation aligns better with the qualitative findings from the study, which showed that 83% of respondents believe students from both family types can perform well with adequate support. The small effect size indicates that while family structure does influence academic outcomes, it is not the sole or even the primary determinant of student success. Rather, the difference appears to be driven by the differential access to resources, support systems, and parental availability that characterize different family configurations.

The mean difference of 0.30 points (on a 4-point scale) translates to a 7.5 percentage point gap in performance (68.8% for single-parent students vs. 76.3% for two-parent students). While this gap is meaningful and warrants intervention, it is not insurmountable. The small effect size suggests that targeted support programs, resource allocation, and community-based interventions could effectively bridge this performance gap.

4.4 Discussion of Findings

This section discusses the research findings in relation to the study's objectives, theoretical framework, and existing literature. The discussion addresses the key research questions and examines the implications of the statistical analysis.

4.4.1 Academic Performance Across Family Structures

The study reveals distinct performance patterns between students from single-parent and two-parent homes. Students from single-parent homes achieved an average performance level with a mean score of 2.75 out of 4.00 (68.8%), while their counterparts from two-parent homes scored 3.05 (76.3%), representing good performance. Although 70% of single-parent students demonstrated strong interest in learning, this intrinsic motivation did not consistently translate into effective study habits (59%) or regular assignment completion (63%). In contrast, two-parent students exhibited more consistent academic behaviors across all indicators, with 83% maintaining good study habits and 79% completing assignments regularly.

This performance differential, while statistically significant ($t = -4.815$, $p < 0.001$), yielded a small effect size (Cohen's $d = 0.482$), indicating that family structure accounts for approximately 19% of the variance in academic performance. The small effect size is crucial for interpretation—it suggests that while family structure influences outcomes, it is not determinative. This aligns with self-determination theory and ecological systems theory, which emphasize that multiple interacting factors shape academic achievement. The finding that 83% of respondents believe students from both family types can succeed with adequate support underscores that capability is not inherently limited by family configuration, but rather by differential access to resources and support systems.

4.4.2 Understanding the Performance Gap: Resources and Support

The performance gap is better understood through the lens of resource availability rather than family structure per se. The data reveal critical deficiencies: 57% of respondents reported that single-parent students lack sufficient resources, 50% indicated inadequate encouragement, and 51% cited limited access to academic mentors. These findings point to systemic barriers—financial constraints, limited parental time due to sole breadwinner responsibilities, and reduced supervision—that impede academic progress regardless of student motivation or capability.

In the Nigerian context, where educational success often depends on families' ability to afford supplementary materials, private lessons, and school fees, single-parent households face disproportionate challenges. The traditional extended family support system that historically buffered these challenges has weakened due to urbanization and economic pressures, leaving many single parents with fewer resources than previous generations enjoyed. This structural reality, rather than parenting quality or student ability, appears to drive the observed performance difference.

4.4.3 Institutional Support and Intervention Gaps

The study reveals concerning inadequacies in institutional support mechanisms. While 62% acknowledged that teachers provide helpful guidance, only 48% agreed that community or school programs effectively support single-parent students, with 52% expressing disagreement. Similarly, 44% found counseling services inadequate, and 42% questioned parent-school collaboration effectiveness. These findings suggest that existing interventions are insufficient, poorly implemented, or inaccessible to those who need them most.

The low confidence in parent-school collaboration is particularly significant, as it reflects practical barriers single parents face in engaging with schools—inflexible work schedules, lack of childcare, and time constraints from managing household responsibilities alone. Schools must adopt more flexible, proactive approaches that accommodate the realities of single-parent families, including evening or weekend meetings, virtual communication options, and targeted outreach to ensure these parents can participate meaningfully in their children's education.

4.4.4 Implications for Policy and Practice

The findings carry significant implications for educational policy and practice in Nigeria. First, the small effect size of family structure on academic performance—coupled with widespread belief in students' potential regardless of family type—calls for a paradigm shift from viewing single-parent families as inherently problematic to addressing the structural inequities they face. Policy interventions should focus on resource provision: subsidized educational materials, scholarship programs for single-parent students, and financial assistance to reduce the economic burden on these families.

Second, schools should implement targeted academic support programs, including after-school tutoring, homework assistance centers, and mentorship initiatives that compensate for limited parental availability. Community partnerships with religious institutions, local businesses, and NGOs can create comprehensive support networks that extend beyond school walls. Third, teacher training programs should equip educators to recognize and respond to the unique challenges facing single-parent students, fostering inclusive classroom environments that provide additional encouragement and support where needed.

Finally, the resilience demonstrated by single-parent students—70% showing strong learning interest despite challenges—highlights protective factors that interventions can strengthen. Programs that build on students' intrinsic motivation while providing practical support (study skills workshops, time management training, peer tutoring) may prove particularly effective in bridging the performance gap.

4.4.5 Theoretical Alignment and Contextual Considerations

These findings align well with ecological systems theory, which emphasizes that child development results from interactions across multiple environmental systems. The study illustrates how limitations in the family microsystem (single-parent structure) interact with exo-system constraints (limited community resources, parental workplace demands) and macrosystem factors (economic conditions, cultural expectations) to shape academic outcomes. The finding that adequate support enables success regardless of family type reinforces the theory's emphasis on environmental quality over structure alone.

Family systems theory's focus on family dynamics and support quality, rather than configuration, is similarly supported. The differential performance reflects varying levels of available support, supervision, and resources rather than inherent family deficits. Within the Oyo Town context, where the study was conducted, these findings must be interpreted alongside local socioeconomic realities and the specific educational infrastructure available. While the fundamental challenges identified likely resonate across Nigeria, local variations in community support, economic conditions, and cultural norms may moderate these effects in different regions.

4.4.6 Study Limitations

Several limitations warrant acknowledgment. The reliance on self-reported perceptions rather than objective academic measures (examination scores, GPAs) limits definitive conclusions about actual performance levels. The cross-sectional design captures a single time point and cannot address how long students have been in single-parent households or track performance changes over time. Additionally, the study does not fully control for confounding variables such as parental education level, socioeconomic status independent of family structure, or parenting quality, which may independently influence outcomes. Future research should incorporate objective performance data, longitudinal designs, and more comprehensive control variables to build on these findings.

4.5 Summary of Findings

This section summarizes the key findings organized by research questions.

Research Question 1: What is the academic performance level of students from single-parent homes?

Students from single-parent homes demonstrated average academic performance (mean = 2.75/4.00; 68.8%). While 70% showed strong interest in learning, indicating resilience and intrinsic motivation, only 59% possessed good study habits, 61% were committed to academic improvement, 63% regularly completed assignments, and 65% participated actively in class. These results suggest that motivation exists but faces challenges in translating into consistent academic behaviors, likely due to limited supervision, resources, and support.

Research Question 2: What is the academic performance level of students from two-parent homes?

Students from two-parent homes achieved good performance (mean = 3.05/4.00; 76.3%). Responses were consistently positive across all indicators: 83% maintained good study habits, 79% completed assignments regularly, 77% participated actively in school activities, 72% showed strong

academic motivation, and 77% achieved high scores. The uniformly strong performance suggests stable family environments that provide effective supervision, emotional support, and academic encouragement.

Research Question 3: Is there a significant difference in academic performance between students from single-parent and two-parent homes?

Yes, a statistically significant difference exists ($t = -4.815$, $p < 0.001$). Two-parent students scored 0.30 points higher (7.5 percentage points). However, the effect size is small (Cohen's $d = 0.482$), meaning family structure accounts for approximately 19% of performance variance. This small effect indicates that while family structure influences outcomes, it does not determine them—other factors play substantial roles, and appropriate support can enable success regardless of family configuration.

Additional Key Findings

Beyond the primary research questions, the study revealed:

Belief in Universal Potential: Despite the performance gap, 83% agreed that students from both family types can perform well with adequate support, recognizing that family structure alone does not determine capability.

Resource Deficits: Critical gaps exist for single-parent students—57% lack sufficient resources, 50% lack adequate encouragement, and 51% lack access to mentors, pointing to systemic rather than individual deficiencies.

Institutional Support Inadequacies: While 62% acknowledged helpful teacher guidance, only 48% found school/community programs effective, 56% found counseling adequate, and 58% viewed parent-school collaboration positively, suggesting current interventions need improvement.

Demographic Context: The sample ($n=200$) comprised 57% males and 43% females, mostly aged 13-18 (72%). Notably, 63% came from single-parent families, indicating these households constitute the majority in the study population.

In conclusion, the study confirms a statistically significant but small performance difference in favor of two-parent students. This gap reflects differential access to resources, support, and parental time rather than inherent differences in student capability. The widespread recognition that adequate support enables success regardless of family type, combined with the small effect size, underscores that targeted interventions addressing resource deficits, enhancing institutional support, and providing flexible engagement opportunities for single parents can effectively bridge the performance gap and ensure equitable educational outcomes for all students.

SUMMARY, CONCLUSION, AND RECOMMENDATIONS

5.1 Summary of the Study

This study investigated the effect of single parenting on the academic performance of secondary school students in Oyo Town, Oyo State, Nigeria. The research was motivated by the increasing prevalence of single-parent households in Nigeria and the need to understand how family structure influences educational outcomes. The study adopted a descriptive survey research design and collected data from 200 secondary school students through structured questionnaires.

The theoretical framework for the study was anchored on Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory, Coleman's Social Capital Theory, and the Family Stress Model. These theories provided a comprehensive lens for understanding how family structure interacts with environmental, social, and psychological factors to influence academic performance. The study formulated five specific objectives and corresponding research questions that guided the investigation.

Data analysis revealed that students from single-parent homes demonstrated average academic performance with a mean score of 2.75 out of 4.00 (68.8%), while students from two-parent homes achieved good performance with a mean score of 3.05 out of 4.00 (76.3%). An independent samples t-test confirmed a statistically significant difference between the two groups ($t = -4.815$, $p < 0.001$), with a small effect size (Cohen's $d = 0.482$), indicating that family structure accounts for approximately 19% of the variance in academic performance.

The study identified critical challenges facing single-parent students, including inadequate financial resources (57% reported insufficiency), limited parental encouragement (50%), and restricted access to academic mentors (51%). Despite these challenges, 83% of respondents agreed that students from both family types can perform well with adequate support, suggesting that the performance gap is attributable to differential access to resources rather than inherent capability differences. The findings also revealed deficiencies in institutional support mechanisms, with only 48% agreeing that school and community programs effectively support single-parent students.

5.2 Summary of Findings

Based on the research questions, the following key findings emerged from the study:

Research Question 1: Academic Performance of Students from Single-Parent Homes

Students from single-parent homes demonstrated average academic performance (mean = 2.75/4.00; 68.8%). While 70% showed strong interest in learning, only 59% possessed good study habits, 61% were committed to academic improvement, 63% regularly completed assignments, and 65% participated actively in class. These findings indicate that while motivation exists among single-parent students, it faces challenges in translating into consistent academic behaviors, likely due to limited supervision, resources, and support.

Research Question 2: Academic Performance of Students from Two-Parent Homes

Students from two-parent homes achieved good performance (mean = 3.05/4.00; 76.3%). Responses were consistently positive across all indicators: 83% maintained good study habits, 79% completed assignments regularly, 77% participated actively in school activities, 72% showed strong academic motivation, and 77% achieved high scores. The uniformly strong performance suggests that stable family environments provide effective supervision, emotional support, and academic encouragement.

Research Question 3: Difference in Academic Performance Between Family Types

A statistically significant difference exists between the two groups ($t = -4.815$, $p < 0.001$), with two-parent students scoring 0.30 points higher (7.5 percentage points). However, the effect size is small (Cohen's $d = 0.482$), meaning family structure accounts for approximately 19% of performance variance. This indicates that while family structure influences outcomes, it does not determine them, and appropriate support can enable success regardless of family configuration.

Research Question 4: Challenges Faced by Single-Parent Students

Single-parent students face multiple interconnected challenges: (a) Resource deficits - 57% lack sufficient educational resources including textbooks, school supplies, and access to supplementary learning materials; (b) Limited parental support - 50% lack adequate encouragement and supervision due to parents' work commitments; (c) Restricted access to mentorship - 51% have insufficient access to academic mentors or guides; (d) Emotional and psychological stress resulting from family disruption; and (e) Time management challenges arising from increased household responsibilities.

Research Question 5: Strategies to Support Single-Parent Students

The study identified several potential interventions: (a) School-based support - 62% acknowledged that teachers provide helpful guidance, but this needs to be strengthened with structured tutoring and mentorship programs; (b) Financial assistance - Subsidized educational materials and scholarship programs to reduce economic burdens; (c) Flexible parent engagement - Accommodating single parents' schedules through evening meetings and virtual communication; (d) Community partnerships - Collaboration with NGOs, religious institutions, and local businesses to provide comprehensive support networks; and (e) Counseling services - Enhanced psychological support, though current services were deemed inadequate by 44% of respondents.

5.3 Conclusion

This study provides empirical evidence on the relationship between family structure and academic performance among secondary school students in Oyo Town, Oyo State. The findings confirm that while students from two-parent homes currently demonstrate higher academic performance compared to their peers from single-parent homes, the difference, though statistically significant, is characterized by a small effect size. This nuanced finding is crucial for proper interpretation and policy formulation.

The research conclusively demonstrates that family structure is not a deterministic factor in academic achievement. Rather, the performance gap observed reflects differential access to resources, support systems, parental time, and institutional assistance. The fact that 83% of

respondents believe students from both family types can excel with adequate support validates this interpretation and challenges deficit-based perspectives on single-parent families.

Single-parent students exhibit considerable resilience and intrinsic motivation, as evidenced by the 70% who demonstrate a strong interest in learning. This resilience represents a significant protective factor that educators and policymakers can leverage. However, this motivation is often undermined by structural barriers, including financial constraints, limited parental availability for academic supervision, inadequate access to educational resources, and insufficient institutional support mechanisms. These are solvable problems that require systemic interventions rather than individual remedies.

The study also reveals significant gaps in current support systems. While teachers are generally perceived as providing helpful guidance, broader institutional mechanisms—including counseling services, school-community partnerships, and parent engagement strategies—are inadequate or poorly implemented. Only 48% of respondents view school and community programs as effective in supporting single-parent students, indicating substantial room for improvement.

Within the Nigerian educational context, where family financial contributions significantly influence access to quality education, single-parent households face compounded disadvantages. The erosion of traditional extended family support networks due to urbanization and economic pressures has left many single parents without the communal assistance that previous generations enjoyed. This contextual reality underscores the urgency of developing targeted, culturally appropriate interventions.

Theoretically, the findings align with Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory, demonstrating that academic outcomes result from complex interactions across multiple environmental systems. The research supports Coleman's Social Capital Theory by showing how single-parent families may have reduced access to social networks that facilitate educational success. The Family Stress Model is validated by evidence that economic and time pressures in single-parent homes create stress that impacts student performance.

Ultimately, this study concludes that the academic performance gap between students from single-parent and two-parent homes is neither inevitable nor insurmountable. With strategic resource allocation, robust institutional support, flexible parent engagement mechanisms, and community partnerships, schools can create equitable conditions that enable all students to achieve their full academic potential regardless of family structure. The small effect size observed suggests that relatively modest but well-targeted interventions could yield meaningful improvements in outcomes for single-parent students.

5.4 Recommendations

Based on the findings and conclusions of this study, the following recommendations are proposed for various stakeholders:

5.4.1 Recommendations for School Administrators and Teachers

Implement Targeted Academic Support Programs: Schools should establish after-school tutoring centers, homework assistance programs, and peer mentoring initiatives specifically designed to

support students who may lack adequate supervision at home. These programs should be free or subsidized to ensure accessibility for economically disadvantaged families.

Develop Flexible Parent Engagement Strategies: Recognize that single parents often have inflexible work schedules. Schools should offer multiple communication channels (phone calls, SMS, email, virtual meetings) and schedule parent-teacher conferences during evenings or weekends. Consider establishing parent liaisons who can bridge communication gaps.

Train Teachers on Family Diversity and Inclusive Practices: Professional development programs should equip teachers with knowledge about diverse family structures and their implications for student needs. Teachers should be trained to recognize signs of stress, resource deficits, or emotional challenges among students and respond with appropriate support and referrals.

Establish School-Based Resource Centers: Create resource centers where students can access textbooks, school supplies, internet-enabled computers, and quiet study spaces. This ensures that resource gaps at home do not translate into academic disadvantages.

Strengthen Counseling and Psychological Support Services: Enhance school counseling services to provide emotional and psychological support for students experiencing family-related stress. Counselors should be specifically trained in addressing challenges associated with single-parent family structures.

5.4.2 Recommendations for Government and Policymakers

Establish Targeted Scholarship Programs: The government should create scholarship and bursary programs specifically for academically capable students from single-parent homes. These programs should cover school fees, textbooks, uniforms, and other essential educational expenses.

Subsidize Educational Resources: Implement policies that provide free or heavily subsidized textbooks, school supplies, and digital learning devices to economically disadvantaged students, with priority given to single-parent households.

Increase Funding for School Support Programs: Allocate dedicated funding for schools to establish and maintain tutoring centers, mentorship programs, counseling services, and parent support initiatives. Hold schools accountable for effectively utilizing these resources.

Develop Community Learning Centers: Establish community learning centers in underserved areas where students can access after-school tutoring, library facilities, internet access, and mentorship. These centers should operate beyond regular school hours to accommodate students' schedules.

Implement Family Support Policies: Develop workplace policies that provide single parents with flexible working arrangements, allowing them greater time for school engagement and homework supervision. Consider subsidized childcare programs that reduce parental stress and time constraints.

5.4.3 Recommendations for Parents (Especially Single Parents)

Prioritize Academic Engagement: Despite time and resource constraints, single parents should make deliberate efforts to monitor their children's academic progress, attend school meetings when possible, and maintain regular communication with teachers. Even brief daily check-ins about homework and school activities can significantly impact student outcomes.

Leverage Community and Extended Family Support: Single parents should actively seek and utilize support from extended family members, community organizations, religious institutions, and parent support groups. Building a network of support can help share responsibilities and provide additional supervision and encouragement for children.

Establish Structured Home Routines: Create consistent daily routines that include designated homework time, limited screen time, regular sleep schedules, and family meals. Structure and predictability can provide stability that supports academic focus and good study habits.

Seek Available Resources and Assistance: Actively pursue available scholarships, bursaries, free tutoring programs, and community resources designed to support single-parent families. Many parents are unaware of existing assistance programs that could alleviate financial and academic support burdens.

Model Resilience and Positive Attitudes Toward Education: Demonstrate resilience, emphasize the value of education, and maintain high but realistic expectations for children's academic achievement. Positive parental attitudes toward education significantly influence children's motivation and academic self-concept.

5.4.4 Recommendations for Community Organizations and NGOs

Establish Mentorship Programs: Develop structured mentorship programs that connect single-parent students with positive adult role models from the community. Mentors can provide academic guidance, emotional support, and exposure to educational and career opportunities.

Create Parent Support Groups: Organize support groups where single parents can share experiences, strategies, and resources for supporting their children's education. These groups can also serve as platforms for disseminating information about available educational assistance programs.

Provide Educational Resource Support: Partner with schools to donate textbooks, school supplies, uniforms, and digital learning devices to students from economically disadvantaged single-parent homes. Establish scholarship funds or educational savings programs for single-parent students.

Offer Skill Development and Employment Support for Single Parents: Provide vocational training, job placement assistance, and financial literacy programs for single parents to improve their economic stability, which directly impacts their ability to support their children's education.

Facilitate Community Learning Spaces: Establish safe community centers where students can study, access the internet, receive tutoring, and participate in enrichment activities after school hours, particularly in underserved neighborhoods.

5.4.5 Recommendations for Students from Single-Parent Homes

Develop Self-Advocacy Skills: Learn to communicate your needs and challenges to teachers, counselors, and school administrators. Most educators are willing to provide additional support when they understand students' specific circumstances.

Utilize Available School Resources: Take full advantage of school libraries, computer labs, tutoring centers, counseling services, and after-school programs. These resources are designed to support your academic success and should be actively utilized.

Build Peer Study Networks: Form study groups with classmates for mutual academic support, shared learning, and encouragement. Peer collaboration can compensate for limited support at home and enhance understanding of difficult concepts.

Develop Effective Time Management and Study Skills: Given potential household responsibilities, learn to manage time efficiently, prioritize tasks, and develop effective study habits. Seek guidance from teachers or counselors on study skills development.

Maintain a Positive Academic Self-Concept: Recognize that family structure does not determine your academic potential. This study shows that with adequate support, students from single-parent homes can achieve academic excellence. Maintain high aspirations and seek support when needed.

5.5 Contribution to Knowledge

This study makes several important contributions to the existing body of knowledge on family structure and academic performance, particularly within the Nigerian educational context:

Empirical Evidence from Nigerian Context: The study provides quantitative empirical data on the relationship between single parenting and academic performance, specifically within Oyo Town, Oyo State, contributing to the limited research available on this topic in Nigeria. Most existing studies on this subject have been conducted in Western contexts, and this research adds valuable Nigerian-specific insights.

Nuanced Understanding of Effect Size: By calculating and interpreting the effect size (Cohen's $d = 0.482$), the study moves beyond simple statistical significance to provide a more nuanced understanding of the practical magnitude of family structure's influence on academic performance. The small effect size challenges deterministic views of family structure and highlights the importance of contextual and support factors.

Resource-Based Explanation of Performance Gaps: The study shifts the discourse from deficit-based models that pathologize single-parent families to resource-based explanations that emphasize differential access to financial, social, and institutional support. This reframing has important implications for intervention design and policy development.

Documentation of Institutional Support Gaps: The research provides empirical evidence of specific deficiencies in school and community support systems for single-parent students, offering concrete targets for institutional improvement. The finding that only 48% view existing programs as effective identifies a critical area for policy intervention.

Validation of Theoretical Frameworks: The study provides empirical support for the applicability of Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory, Coleman's Social Capital Theory, and the Family Stress Model in the Nigerian educational context, demonstrating that these theories can effectively explain academic outcomes across diverse cultural settings.

Evidence for Resilience and Potential: By documenting that 70% of single-parent students demonstrate strong interest in learning and that 83% of respondents believe students from both family types can succeed with adequate support, the study provides empirical evidence for the resilience and potential of single-parent students, countering stigmatizing narratives.

Identification of Specific Intervention Targets: The research identifies specific, actionable areas for intervention, including resource provision (57% gap), parental encouragement (50% gap), mentorship access (51% gap), and institutional support mechanisms, providing evidence-based targets for program development.

5.6 Suggestions for Further Studies

While this study provides valuable insights into the relationship between single parenting and academic performance, several areas warrant further investigation to deepen understanding and inform more effective interventions:

Longitudinal Studies on Academic Trajectories: Future research should employ longitudinal designs to track academic performance over time, examining how long students have been in single-parent households and whether performance patterns change as students' progress through secondary school. This would provide insights into adaptation processes and long-term effects that cross-sectional studies cannot capture.

Incorporation of Objective Academic Measures: Subsequent studies should complement perceptual data with objective academic performance indicators such as examination scores, grade point averages, and standardized test results. This would provide more definitive evidence about actual performance levels and validate or challenge perceptual findings.

Examination of Mediating and Moderating Variables: Research should investigate variables that mediate or moderate the relationship between family structure and academic performance, including parental education level, socioeconomic status independent of family structure, parenting quality, student resilience factors, peer relationships, and teacher support. Understanding these mechanisms would enable more targeted interventions.

Comparative Studies Across Different Regions: Given Nigeria's cultural and socioeconomic diversity, studies should be conducted in other regions (Northern, Eastern, and other Western states) to examine whether findings from Oyo Town are generalizable or reflect regional variations. Urban-rural comparisons would also be valuable.

Qualitative Exploration of Student and Parent Experiences: In-depth qualitative studies using interviews and focus groups with single parents and their children could provide rich insights into the lived experiences, coping strategies, challenges, and resilience factors that quantitative studies cannot fully capture. Mixed-methods approaches combining quantitative and qualitative data would be particularly valuable.

Evaluation of Intervention Program Effectiveness: Research should rigorously evaluate the effectiveness of specific intervention programs designed to support single-parent students, such as tutoring programs, mentorship initiatives, counseling services, and parent support groups. Evidence-based evaluation would identify best practices and cost-effective interventions.

Investigation of Gender Differences: Future studies should examine whether the effects of single parenting on academic performance differ between male and female students, and whether students raised by single mothers versus single fathers experience different outcomes. Gender-disaggregated analysis would inform gender-responsive interventions.

Exploration of Subject-Specific Performance: Research should investigate whether single parenting differentially affects performance across academic subjects (sciences, humanities, mathematics, etc.). Some subjects may be more vulnerable to resource or support gaps than others.

Examination of Transition Points: Studies should focus on critical transition points in students' academic careers (primary to secondary school transition, junior to senior secondary transition, secondary to tertiary transition) to understand how family structure influences navigation of these transitions and long-term educational attainment.

Investigation of Protective Factors and Resilience: Research should identify specific protective factors that enable some single-parent students to excel despite challenges. Understanding resilience mechanisms could inform strengths-based interventions that build on existing capabilities rather than focusing solely on deficit remediation.

Cost-Benefit Analysis of Support Programs: Economic research should conduct cost-benefit analyses of different intervention strategies to guide efficient resource allocation. Understanding which interventions provide the greatest return on investment would support evidence-based policymaking.

Cross-Cultural Comparative Studies: International comparative studies examining single parenting and academic performance across different cultural and educational contexts could identify universal patterns and culture-specific factors, informing culturally appropriate intervention design.

5.7 Limitations of the Study

Despite the valuable insights provided, this study has several limitations that should be acknowledged:

Reliance on Self-Reported Perceptions: The study relied primarily on students' perceptions of academic performance rather than objective academic data (examination scores, GPAs). While perceptions are important, they may not perfectly align with actual performance levels and are subject to response biases.

Cross-Sectional Design: The cross-sectional nature of the study captures data at a single point in time and cannot establish causal relationships or track changes over time. Longitudinal studies would provide stronger evidence about the effects of single parenting on academic trajectories.

Geographic Limitation: The study was conducted exclusively in Oyo Town, Oyo State, and findings may not be fully generalizable to other regions of Nigeria with different cultural, economic, and educational contexts. The unique characteristics of Oyo Town may influence results.

Limited Sample Size: With 200 respondents, while adequate for statistical analysis, a larger sample size would provide greater statistical power and enable more sophisticated analyses, including examination of subgroup differences by age, gender, and socioeconomic status.

Incomplete Control of Confounding Variables: The study did not fully control for confounding variables such as parental education level, household income independent of family structure, parenting quality, and duration of single-parent status. These factors may independently influence academic performance and could partially explain observed differences.

Potential Selection Bias: The stratified random sampling technique, while appropriate, may still be subject to selection biases if certain types of students were more or less likely to participate. Non-response bias could also affect results if certain groups declined participation at higher rates.

Limited Exploration of Qualitative Dimensions: The quantitative approach, while providing valuable statistical evidence, does not capture the rich qualitative experiences, narratives, and contextual nuances that interviews or focus groups could reveal.

Measurement Limitations: The study used a 4-point Likert scale, which, while standard, may not fully capture the complexity of academic performance and family influences. Some respondents may have interpreted scale items differently, introducing measurement error.

Despite these limitations, this study makes important contributions to understanding the relationship between family structure and academic performance in the Nigerian context and provides a solid foundation for future research and evidence-based policy development.

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APPENDICES

QUESTIONNAIRE

THE EFFECT OF SINGLE PARENTING ON THE ACADEMIC PERFORMANCE OF SECONDARY SCHOOL STUDENTS IN OYO TOWN, OYO STATE, NIGERIA

SECTION A: Demographic Information

(Kindly tick ☐ in the appropriate options)

Gender: Male Female

Age: 10-12 13-15 16-18

Class: ☐ JSS1 ☐ JSS2 ☐ JSS3 ☐ SS1 ☐ SS2 ☐ SS3

Family Type: Single-parent Home Two-parent Home

SECTION B: Academic performance level of students from single-parent homes

Instruction: Kindly tick the option that best reflects your opinion.

SA = Strongly Agree | A = Agree | D = Disagree | SD = Strongly Disagree

SECTION C: Academic performance level of students from two-parent homes

Instruction: Kindly tick the option that best reflects your opinion.

SA = Strongly Agree | A = Agree | D = Disagree | SD = Strongly Disagree

SECTION D: Difference in academic performance between single-parent and two-parent homes

Instruction: Kindly tick the option that best reflects your opinion.

SA = Strongly Agree | A = Agree | D = Disagree | SD = Strongly Disagree

SECTION E: Challenges faced by students from single-parent homes (positive framing)

Instruction: Kindly tick the option that best reflects your opinion.

SA = Strongly Agree | A = Agree | D = Disagree | SD = Strongly Disagree

SECTION F: Strategies and interventions to support academic success of single-parent students

Instruction: Kindly tick the option that best reflects your opinion.

SA = Strongly Agree | A = Agree | D = Disagree | SD = Strongly Disagree